

with 'VBOXADDITIONS' or something similar). Assuming your guest OS is 32-bit Linux (like my Fedora installation) then run `/VBoxLinuxAdditions-x86.run` to begin installing GA. Figure 7 shows an ongoing GA installation, and a list of installer files for various guest OS types.

After installing GA

After GA installation is complete, unmount/eject the 'CD'. You can also (on the VirtualBox window for your VM) click the menu **Devices > CD/DVD Devices**, and un-check the 'VBoxGuestAdditions.iso' item, to disconnect the media from the VM. If you had added it under the VM's **Storage** settings, you can shut down the VM's guest OS, and remove it from that settings pane. In any case, the GA installation prompts you to (recommended) restart the guest OS to ensure that the new drivers are used.

Setting up a shared folder

Once your VM is booted again, click **Devices > Shared Folders** on the VM window. Or, before booting the VM, visit **Shared Folders** in VM settings. In either case, click the add button, and select a folder in your host OS filesystem. For the **Folder Name**, I recommend a short and simple name without any spaces; I used 'New'. Click **OK**. (If the VM is not running, start it up.)

In the guest OS, open a terminal window as the root user, and to mount the shared folder, run a mount command with the syntax `mount -t vboxsf <sharedFolderName> <mountPoint>`. For example (as root), I created the folder `/mnt/shared`. To mount my shared folder, I used the following command:

```
mount -t vboxsf New /mnt/shared
```

Now you can access the contents of the shared folder under the mount-point you used.

By: Ankur Aggarwal

The author loves to explore open source technologies and enjoys programming. He has learned C, C++, core Java, and Python. He loves rock/metal music and has been trying his hand at the guitar. He has also started a blog recently: www.flossstuff.wordpress.com and can be contacted via coolankur2006@gmail.com or on Twitter as @ankurtwti.

Sharing from a Linux host to a WinXP guest OS

Install GA in the VM (WinXP should auto-run the installer when the ISO is connected), reboot the VM, and set up the shared folder in VirtualBox as described earlier. To access the shared folder, open **My Computer** in the guest WinXP; in the left panel, right-click **My Network Places > Map Network Drive**. Then select **Browse**. Expand **VirtualBox Shared Folders > \\Vboxsvr**; select the shared folder '\\VBOXSVR\\New' (as shown in Figure 8) and click **OK**. After the shared folder is mapped as a network drive, you can access its contents via **My Computer** (Windows Explorer).

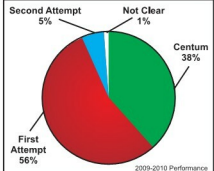
Drawbacks

I found some problems with the OSE version of the VirtualBox:

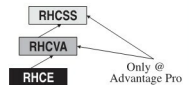
- There is no USB support in the OSE, unlike the Oracle PUEL version, because of which iPod syncing is a problem. Shared folders help to address this problem.
- Sometimes, while starting the OSE, the `vboxdrv` module (in the host OS) fails to load, and you see an error message. However, you can simply load it manually with `sudo modprobe vboxdrv` and then start the VM again, and it works fine.
- After working for a long time in the guest OS, my keyboard stopped working, requiring me to restart the VM. This problem is very rare, though; till now, I've faced it only 2-3 times.

Well, I hope this is sufficient information for you to get started using VirtualBox virtual machines for fun, work and to learn. The Web will provide you with more information, should you need it! 

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